

Yarn substitution cheat sheet

The pattern calls for a yarn you can't get, or don't want to pay for. Here's how to swap it without wrecking the gauge — and what changes when you switch fibre.

STANDARD YARN WEIGHTS

#	NAME	WPI	KNIT GAUGE / 4"	NEEDLE	CROCHET GAUGE / 4"	HOOK
0	Lace	30-40+	33-40 sts	1.5-2.25 mm	32-42 dc	1.4-2.25 mm
1	Super fine / fingering, sock	14-30	27-32 sts	2.25-3.25 mm	21-32 sc	2.25-3.5 mm
2	Fine / sport	12-18	23-26 sts	3.25-3.75 mm	16-20 sc	3.5-4.5 mm
3	Light / DK	11-15	21-24 sts	3.75-4.5 mm	12-17 sc	4.5-5.5 mm
4	Medium / worsted, aran	9-12	16-20 sts	4.5-5.5 mm	11-14 sc	5.5-6.5 mm
5	Bulky / chunky	6-9	12-15 sts	5.5-8 mm	8-11 sc	6.5-9 mm
6	Super bulky	5-6	7-11 sts	8-12.75 mm	7-9 sc	9-15 mm
7	Jumbo	0-4	6 or fewer	12.75 mm+	6 or fewer	15 mm+

WPI = wraps per inch. Wrap the yarn snugly around a ruler for one inch and count the wraps. It's the fastest way to identify an unlabelled yarn from your stash.

THE FIVE RULES OF SUBSTITUTING

1. **Buy yards, not grams.** Two 100g skeins of different fibres can differ by 150 yards. The pattern's yardage is the number that matters.
2. **Swatch, then trust the swatch — not the label.** Ball bands state the manufacturer's gauge, not yours. Wash and block the swatch before you measure it.
3. **Two strands of a lighter weight ≈ one of a heavier.** Two fingering held together lands close to DK or light worsted. Two DK lands near bulky. Useful for using up a stash.
4. **Match the fabric, not just the number.** A drapey shawl in stiff cotton at the correct gauge is still the wrong garment.
5. **Buy one spare skein in the same dye lot.** Lots shift noticeably, and running short at the last row is the worst possible time to discover it.

WHAT CHANGES WHEN YOU CHANGE FIBRE

FIBRE	DRAPE & BEHAVIOUR	WATCH OUT FOR
Wool	Elastic, forgiving, blocks beautifully and holds its shape	Can felt; some people find it itchy
Superwash wool	Soft, machine washable, excellent stitch definition	Grows and can sag — go down a size
Cotton	Crisp, cool, great for dishcloths and summer tops	Heavy, no memory, hard on the hands
Acrylic	Cheap, durable, washable, huge colour range	Won't block — the shape off the hook is the final shape
Alpaca	Warm, silky, gorgeous drape	Grows lengthwise under its own weight
Cotton/acrylic blend	Balanced — most of the wash-and-wear, less of the weight	Stitch definition softer than pure cotton
Mohair / brushed	Halo, lightness, warmth without bulk	Nearly impossible to frog cleanly

THE SUBSTITUTION MATHS

Skeins you need = pattern yardage ÷ yards per skein of the new yarn — then round up.

Example: the pattern needs 1,200 yards. Your yarn has 218 yards per skein. $1,200 \div 218 = 5.5 \rightarrow$ **buy 6** (and honestly, buy 7).

Gauge adjustment: if your swatch has more stitches per 4" than the pattern, go up a hook or needle size. Fewer stitches, go down. Change one size at a time and re-swatch.

USING THIS WITH STASHKEEPER

StashKeeper records what you own and what you're making — this sheet is the reference that sits alongside it. In **Yarn Stash**, log brand, colourway, fibre type, weight, dye lot, yards bought and yards left. In **Projects**, save the pattern URL, the yards needed and your notes. **Row Counter** keeps your place; **Tools** holds the hooks and needles you own so you can check before you buy. Gauge and WPI aren't tracked in StashKeeper — that's what this page is for. Keep it printed in your project bag.